

Google Voice on PC

Google appears to be testing some kind of desktop application for Google Voice

More GPU powered browsing

NVIDIA demonstrates IE9 browser acceleration on their ION platform

setting changes, no defragging, no wallpapers changes or anything of that sort.

We would run the same tests again but this time with the software installed and all the data in place. The added bulk of the software on the drive as well as in the registry should have slowed things down. Once we had the system somewhat loaded with software like it would be in most cases with most users. That's when their PCs are the slowest. Care was even taken to ensure the same data was dumped on the same partition and the same software installed in the same order on both operating systems.

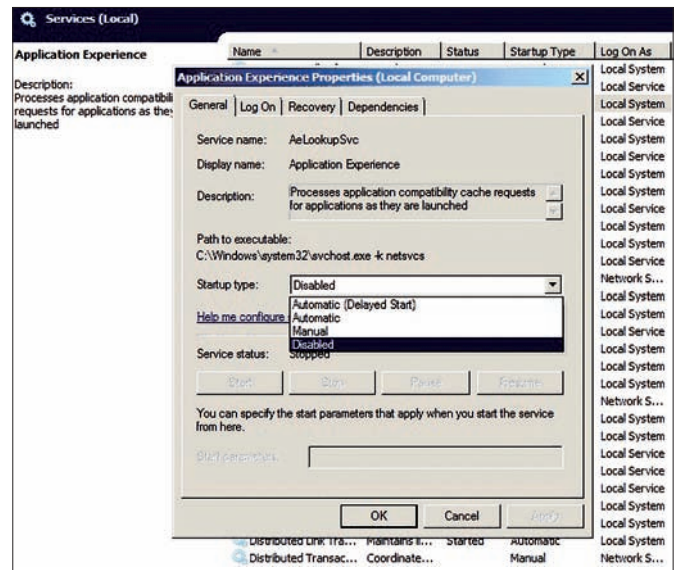
Now, we had to try and fix things. We first tried a simple system defrag first to see if it made things any better. The next in line was a registry cleaning and temporary folders cleanup using a popular free system maintenance utility – CCleaner. Some people feel that page files are unnecessary because the OS along with the software rarely uses more than 1 GB to 2 GB, and since most people today upgrade to systems with 2 GB or more of memory, why use a slower hard drive based page file system. We disabled the page file that was automati-

cally set by Windows for this test. Finally, we ran it with all the unnecessary system processes and services turned off. This should technically lower system resource consumption and therefore speed things up. We referred a few online web pages and recommended services to be shut and then decided on a few of our own as well. The aim of this trial was to see how much of an improvement these tweaks and processes caused and if there would there be any stability issues.

What tests were run

We chose to use the two most popular Windows operating systems of the decade – Windows XP and the recent favourite Windows 7. We setup a plan to run benchmarks on these two operating systems on an identical system which would run a couple of applications and tests to gauge the performance.

Our system configuration was a very basic Intel Pentium 4 with 2 GB of RAM, and a dated but healthy WD Caviar 80 GB hard drive. There was data on the second partition which wasn't tampered with. We used the same configuration on both the operating sys-



Disabling unnecessary services on Windows

tems. All the benchmarks and steps we ran were simulated in the same order on both the operating systems.

The first step was to install the operating systems. Once installed, we updated the necessary device drivers. There were some software such as the Firefox browser, Cinebench 11.5 and also Quake III Arena which we installed.

We ran all real-world tests that Windows users could relate too. A random PCMark score says little. Time taken to start a Windows application or frame rate in games on the

other hand gives us a clearer picture of performance. Some of the tests we ran were the bootup and shutdown time for Windows. The bootup time the time began the Windows bootup screen showed up and ended when the desktop was displayed with all the system tray icons. To avoid interruptions in the bootup, we set only one user account with no passwords.

We ran our favourite Quake III Arena benchmark as well to see gaming performance and then, also recorded the time for a small patch render in Cinebench. File-transfer times for a folder 1.5 GB folder were also recorded. Firefox was the application we used to record application startup time and we also ran Peacemaker, a free web-based browser performance testing tool. We wanted to look as many aspects as possible and we did whatever we could with the number of test scenarios we had set.

Our observation

Windows startup times are the first to be hit as you install more software. Copying files, moving

Windows XP vs Windows 7 Performance

	Startup time	Shutdown time	Firefox startup	Peacemaker (points)	Quake 3 (fps)	Cinebench (sec)	1 GB Copy (sec)
Windows XP (SP3)							
Windows XP clean	28.78	6.38	5.03	1984	223	52.06	112
Windows XP software installed	30.00	13.97	4.55	1978	223.4	54.00	122
Windows XP defragged	25.60	25.81	5.47	1979	223.6	52.44	125
Windows XP Registry cleaned	25.88	26.59	5.09	1929	223.5	52.88	126
Windows XP with no page file	26.31	23.97	4.50	1981	223.6	53.22	159
Windows XP with services off	22.06	5.39	2.66	1966	223.4	52.47	130
Windows 7							
Windows 7 clean	33.25	8.06	5.63	1887	229.2	54.22	84
Windows 7 software installed	35.78	10.35	3.53	1850	230.6	55.12	106
Windows 7 defragged	35.69	7.97	6.50	1842	229.7	55.47	98
Windows 7 Registry cleaned	30.25	8.72	1.66	1841	229.7	55.36	99
Windows 7 with no page file	28.19	7.36	2.59	1863	229.6	55.31	110
Windows 7 with services off	20.75	7.22	3.16	1852	230.6	56.44	97